

The rest came from presentation: an indoor, floodlit format with glamour, layered over a sport that remained raw in nature. “No padding,” Gupta says. “These players are tackling each other, but they’re not wearing any protective gear.”

None of it happened by accident. Mashal Sports and Star India studied global examples and adapted those lessons to kabaddi, standardising the fan experience across stadiums. With the federation, they also introduced rule innovations such as the super tackle and do-or-die raid to improve the game.

THE EXPANSION PHASE

By its fifth season, PKL made its next big bet: expanding from eight teams to 12, and from roughly 60 matches a season to well over 130.

“It could have gone either way,” Gupta says. “But there was commitment and there was a belief that kabaddi required additional franchises.” And it paid off.

By contrast, the Hockey India League folded after two seasons, while the Indian Super League has run for more than a decade but has not achieved PKL’s scale.

Neither hockey’s heritage nor football’s money matched what an under-resourced, unglamorous sport pulled off through fast-moving, aligned stakeholders.

In November 2024, Reliance Industries merged its media assets with Disney Star in an \$8.5 billion deal that created JioStar, India’s largest entertainment company.

The deal was primarily aimed at creating a media behemoth, but it also led to change in ownership for Mashal Sports

HOW KABADDI IS WINNING INDIA’S LIVING ROOMS

Viewership of sports leagues in India



SOURCE MEDIA REPORTS, BT RESEARCH

and PKL. Reliance is not new to sports: it owns Mumbai Indians in cricket and Football Sports Development Ltd, which owns and operates the ISL.

“PKL couldn’t have got a better owner at this juncture. The league is already growing, and

with a deep-pocketed owner that understands the sports ecosystem and has ample experience in running a sports league, has massive potential to scale further under the new ownership,” an industry insider told BT.